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COL-800801

Meeting Room, Rayashki

Evgeni had always been a man of action, straightforward and efficient. It seems obvious that this would be reflected by the state of his locker.

That said, Vila is taken aback to find only a small iron box inside.

Vila: ... Alright.

Steadying a tremble in her hands, she picks up the box.

Vila: Comrade Evgeni's name is engraved on the underside.

The teacher lifts the lid, taking out a letter inside. Taking a deep breath before reading it aloud.

Vila: "You are reading this, and so I am gone. Don't waste your time on tears or anger."

Vila: So typical of Evgeni ...

Vila: "Within this box are plans for Rayashki's reconstruction and development. I know that my perspective is limited ..."

Vila: "Yet, it is my hope that these plans may provide the town with some direction in my absence."

Vila: "Our primary focus must be the exploitation and administration of our resources."

Vila: "I've listed those I consider most feasible to pursue and their potential trade value, as well as listing any necessary precautions."

Vila: "Once our future is secure, look to the maintenance of the town's infrastructure, and if possible, bolster security, starting with regular patrols at locations frequented by critters."

Vila: "Another thing, I've spent some time collecting scraps and spare components of runium left over from the factories. You will find them in this box."

Vila: "I made some further notes, from before all this seemed inevitable, you'll find them detailed in my work journal on the desk."

Vila: "I know that many among you will never trust them. But, please do not discount the possibility of cooperating with Zeno. Remember, our priority must be survival."

Vila: "I wish for all of you great things, and victory in our coming trials."

Vila: "Know that I salute you, each and every comrade. For Rayashki, for our future, Evgeni."

Vila: ... The letter ends there.

Knut: ...

Knut: Even in a letter, he is as always he has been, our Comrade Evgeni, stubborn to the end.

Knut: Pah, it was a fool's hope that he'd show a little heart. No, it's not like him ...

Vila: You're wrong, Knut. This was his heart. Comrade Evgeni always put the town first.

Vila: But then, perhaps he had too much to say, and certainly there was not enough time ...

Vila: Come on, let's pull ourselves back together. We'll need to retrieve his journal.

Vila: I will share this letter with the others later. Comrade Evgeni was right—we must start making plans for Rayashki's future.

One careful fold after another.

Vila places the letter back into the box and closes the lid.

Vila: Come on, comrade.

Knut: Okay. Once we're done, though, let's head to the cliffside and give that stubborn bastard an earful ...

Knut: Speaking of, now that we're getting steady shipments again, we might bring out some vodka for him too ...

# [English text unavailable]

COL-800802

Factory, Rayashki

Knut: How is the machinery for the mine coming along, comrades?

Knut: Don't worry, if it is not finished. I'll transport what we have now and come back later—saves everyone some time!

Elena: Come on, make way, comrades. Let Knut take a closer look.

Knut: Haha, don't tell me you've completed everything overnight?

Knut: So, go on then! What is this, a surprise for old Uncle Knut?!

Elena: As you can see, our work is nearly done! But we've got more than that for you, "Uncle Knut." The team spent some of their rest time repairing those old tools you sent our way.

Adrian: Many still had a bit of use left in them. It would be a waste to just melt down what we could fix.

Adrian: Put your trust in our craftsmanship. Take these tools along with you—I'm sure our comrades at the mine will appreciate them.

Arthur: And if anything gets worn out or isn't working just right, let us know and we'll have it fixed right up.

Adrian: Ah, if only we had more time and some quality materials! Imagine what we could accomplish ...

Knut: Plenty of opportunities for that soon, now that supplies are coming in.

Knut: First priority for now is to fill Comrade Patrik's pantries, so he can fill our bellies! Everyone deserves a good meal after what we've been through.

Knut: In a couple of days, Comrade Vila will begin distribution of our other wares. Then we might start looking after the things we've been missing so long.

Arthur: If only ... if only Comrade Evgeni could see us now. How long has it been since the last time we were able to sit together and just rest, you know?

They try to put it out of mind so that they can focus on the work of reconstruction, but their comrade's sacrifice is not something so easily forgotten.

At the docks, the school, the mining camps, everywhere ... anywhere comrades roll up their sleeves, raise glasses, say farewells, or give a salute ...

His name always comes to mind.

Elena: Enough, enough. Let's finish the task at hand, and do it well. Then we can tell Comrade Evgeni just how proud he should be of us.

Elena: We're still up against the clock, but if we push through, our children will have a better tomorrow!

Adrian: Our bright future still lies ahead!

Knut: Well said, comrades.

He claps his hands, diverting the conversation to a new topic.

Knut: Remember, the celebration is coming soon. If anyone can spare their time, we need all the hands we can get to finish preparations.

Knut: Also, soon enough, we will begin packing the kids' luggage.

Knut: Oh, and should you have any concerns, look for Ms. Ulyana. She has just returned to town and is available for questions.

Elena: Understood, Comrade! Well, well, look at you, Knut. Checking things off, right down the list.

The workers all laugh heartily. A few of them pat Knut on the shoulder.

Knut: It can't be helped. Someone must step up to bear these responsibilities, so here I am ... Not so easy a job, you know.

Knut: Alright. I'm off to the mine, before you lot keep me here any longer! See you at the canteen tonight. I hear that Comrade Patrik is serving stew!

Not long after Knut leaves, another burst of laughter and commotion erupts from outside.

Adrian: Seems our comrades outside offered to help Knut load the equipment. Will he ever get to the mine at this rate?

Elena: Leave Knut to his work, and let's get back to ours!

Adrian: Alright, alright.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-800803

Canteen, Rayashki

After checking the menu for the celebration against their food stocks, Vila falls weightily into the nearest chair.

Between her work schedule and rehearsals, a moment off her feet feels like dipping into a cool pond.

Vila: Phew ...

The cook leaves, grumbling over a long list of requested dishes. With some time left until the next mealtime, the canteen falls into total quiet.

Her arms stretch wide, then fall back, propping up the musical instrument laying precariously on her lap.

Vila: I remember Comrade Simonov warning me about you, "The accordion is a great challenge ..."

Vila: You are much too large, too heavy, and too hard to maintain. Still, I brought you here with me, along with my paint supplies.

Vila: Yes, I admit it. You have been helpful, just as I expected.

Melody flows out as she presses the keys and operates the bellows, in a motion not unlike how she used to part the waters with her hands.

It was a song once used to welcome new visitors. Now, it would welcome Rayashki's future.

Vila: "Don't look behind, no shadows will be seen in the daylight."

Vila: "Under brighter skies, we leave on our journey."

Vila: Oh, that key was a bit too high ...

Her rest is cut shorter even than expected.

???: I'm sorry, Ms. Vila. I'm here to—

Avgust: Vila!

Avgust: Ha, I knew that you would be in the canteen, because that's what you told Ms. Ulyana in the morning!

The teacher barely has time to put aside her accordion.

In the blink of an eye, a living torpedo in a fluffy winter hat dives into Vila's arms, still holding his iconic sunflower.

Vila: Avgust?

Avgust: Teehee, good afternoon, Vila!

Name Day: My apologies, Ms. Vila ... Avgust grabbed hold of me right after I left the classroom. He said he was looking for you, and I didn't feel comfortable letting him go alone ...

Name Day: Incidentally, I had my own reasons to speak to you, Ms. Vila. My colleagues and I are planning to leave tomorrow.

Vila: Tomorrow? That's quite sudden ... Comrade Windsong, the ley lines researcher you asked about, hasn't finished her work at the mining site.

Vila: I don't think she will have time to return before tomorrow ... Too bad I couldn't introduce her to you.

The news of departure grabs the child's attention.

Avgust: Oh, you're leaving already? Ms. Ulyana just returned from outside. Does that mean you will return someday too?

Name Day: Of course ... It's only temporary. We will visit again as agreed.

Name Day: Or did you think I'd forgotten about the arcanum training session we promised?

Avgust: Yes. So then, like Ms. Ulyana, you will ride the moving house and go far outside Rayashki, and you will come back, because you promised.

The little boy nods seriously, and the sunflower sways forward with him.

Vila: I see. Then I wish you all a safe and pleasant journey.

Name Day: Thank you for your understanding, Ms. Vila.

Avgust: Oh, oh, I have a question. Is the Foundation bigger than Rayashki? Oh, and do they have their own rocks, sunflowers, and Avgust there?

Name Day: ... Sadly, you will have to bring your own when you come to visit.

Vila: But, they will have many, many things you've never seen before, little Avgust.

Vila: And you can write about them in your notebook and tell everyone here about them when you return. Or you can stay there a bit longer—it's up to you.

Avgust: Why do we have to go there, not the other way around? It sounds like Rayashki is much better—it already has Avgust, plus Vila, Mama, and snowmen!

A simple question, so difficult to answer.

Name Day: Avgust, once you and your friends arrive, the Foundation will have Avgust too. And Ms. Vila can visit anytime.

Vila: That's correct. And, Avgust, you've learned from your mother how to build the very best snowmen, right? I bet you can show everyone at the Foundation how to build them too.

Avgust: So ... Vila, you will come to the Foundation to see us, right?

Vila: Of course, as soon as things settle down here. I won't make you wait long. Promise.

Avgust: If it is a promise, okay. I want to go play with Pyotr now. See you, Ms. Vila. See you, Mr. Raccoon!

The small figure shoots out through the doorway, and the sunflower bobs away with him.

The adults breathe out a held-in sigh of relief.

Name Day: Maybe Rayashki is indeed a better place than the Foundation.

Vila: Haha, you won't get an argument from me. What we've built here with our own hands ... it's hard not to take pride in it.

Vila: But I didn't expect visitors would think so too. Isn't the Foundation to you what Rayashki is to us?

Name Day: Not quite. All I did was push open the right door while passing through Leningrad—nothing at all like what you've done here.

Name Day: There probably won't ever be another place like Rayashki. I can see it's already changing so fast, getting better and better. A place like this, it deserves to thrive, to exist forever.

Vila: Yes, and it will. As long as we stand together.

Vila: But I hope that there will be more towns like ours and that someone will be inspired to build the next Rayashki after their visit here.

Vila: That's why we agreed to send the children to the Foundation.

Name Day: Glad to hear you say that, Ms. Vila.

Name Day: Well, I am sure you're very busy. I won't disturb you any longer ...

Vila: See you, Mr. Name Day.

The young man's figure passes out into the snow outside, leaving the teacher alone again with her thoughts.

Will Rayashki exist forever?

Vila: The pioneers pried open the ice and rock here, a small dot of life on the permafrost.

Vila: And this small dot became "Rayashki."

Vila: So many hands passing along the dream, holding on to one another. As one goes, another comes to raise it a little higher.

Vila: It may be buried in snow, occupied by monsters, or crushed under the weight of adversities ... but we will always rebuild.

Vila: Yes, we will.

She raises her clenched fists gently.

It was a challenge greater than crossing the wrathful waves and escaping from her kin ... A challenge even greater than this accordion.

Sunlight falls into the canteen, illuminating the tabletop, and causing the Rusalka's scales to sparkle in the soft light.

The snow will keep falling, and the path ahead leads forward into forever. Each of us that walks along it does our best to leave a trail for those that follow.

There's still a little time before the rehearsal starts, enough for her to catch her breath and hum through a song.

Vila: Slowly, the minutes float by.

Vila: We don't expect to meet them anymore.